

Chords in context

The same interval, or chord, can be diatonic or chromatic depending on its context—the prevailing key signature. In the example below, the C chord in D major would happen in passing unless handled very carefully—too much chromaticism causes music to sound directionless, or random.



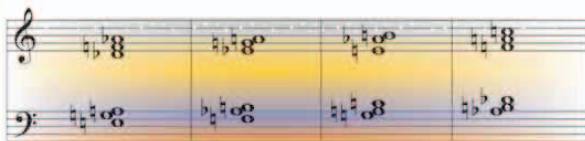
△ When a C chord is chromatic

A chord based on a root triad of C major becomes chromatic in D major because the C $\sharp$ is chromatic in the context of the C $\sharp$ of the key signature.

LOOKING CLOSER

Harmony in color

The term “chromatic” derives from the Greek word *chromos* meaning color, as chromatic harmonies seem more colorful to the ear than purer consonant chords. Color and sound can merge in unexpected ways. Synesthesia is a rare condition that causes people to “see” things like sounds, emotions, and concepts.

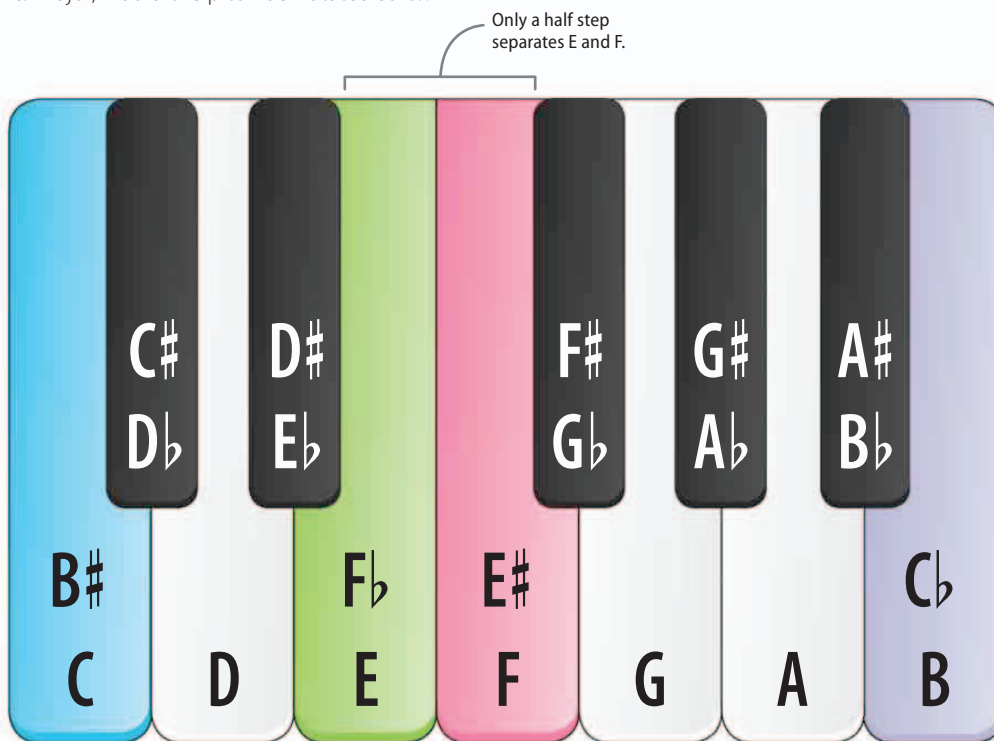


△ Colors in a chord

For French organist and composer Olivier Messiaen, a chord of transposed inversions on C $\sharp$ contained the colors of rock crystal and citrine at the top, copper with gold highlights at the bottom, and sapphire blue rimmed with violet in the middle.

Naming pitches

We decide how to name a given pitch within the rules of diatonic harmony. These names are known as enharmonic equivalents. For example, F $\sharp$ and G $\flat$ are the same pitch, but only if we were writing in G $\flat$ major or its subdominant, C $\flat$ major, would the pitch be notated as G $\flat$.



◁ Enharmonic equivalents

Note that C $\flat$ is not B $\sharp$ because there is only a semitone between B and C. Looking at, or visualizing, a keyboard is a simple way to remember the enharmonic equivalents.